

Kanazawa castle town

Then-and-now aerial photographs, how the ground was made, and the disasters people chose to remember — compiled automatically from public Japanese government data.



金沢城下 (金沢市)

Study area	2.2 km × 1.4 km around 36.5650° N, 136.6600° E
Oldest aerial photograph	1961–1969
Aerial series in this brief	1961–1969, 1974–1978, 2024
Main natural landform	Plateaus and terraces (50%)
Former river channels	none mapped
Filled, reclaimed or drained land	none mapped
Former sea, river or pond	none mapped
Meiji-era paddies, marsh and flats	rice paddy 5.7%, uncultivated land 0.9%, sand and gravel 0.7%
Disaster memorials within 3 km	0

What this brief is. A reading aid for comparing the same ground across decades. It shows what the photographs and GSI's land surveys record; it does not describe current conditions, access or opening hours.

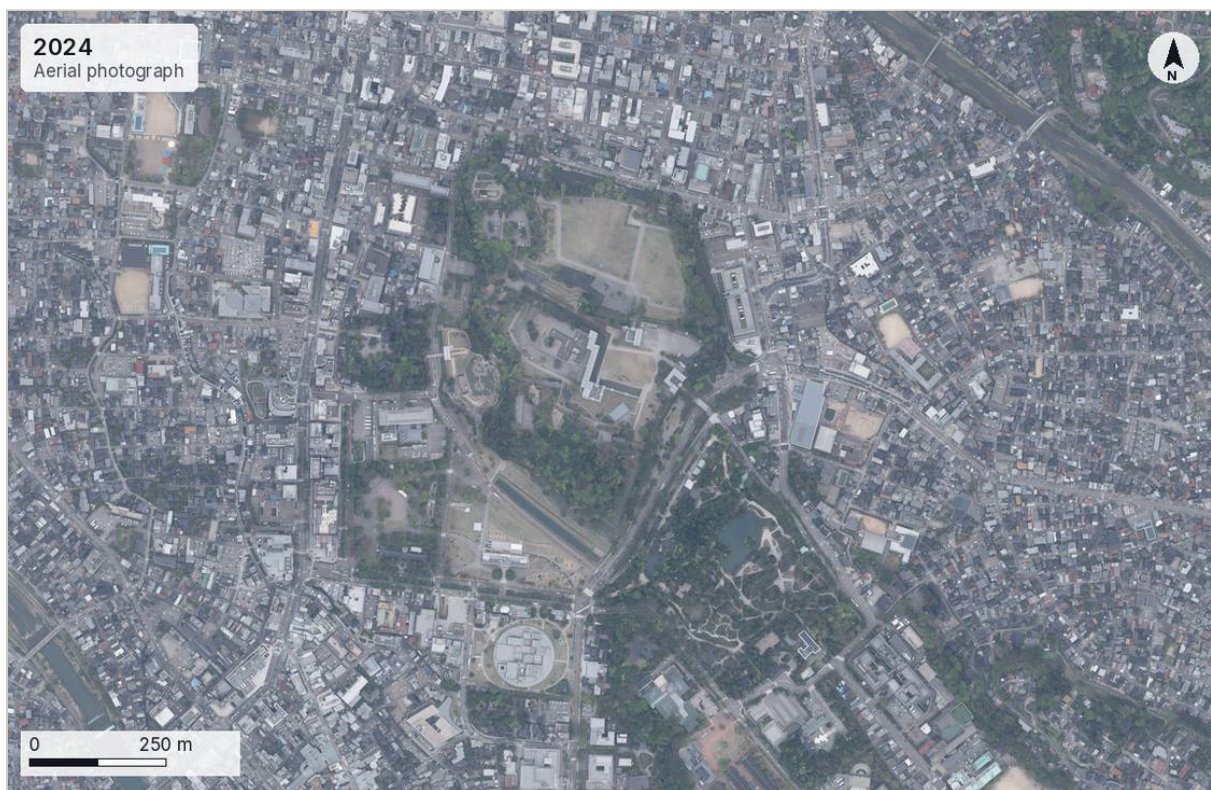
What it is not. Not a hazard assessment or a property survey. Landform classes describe typical tendencies of the ground; for present-day risk, read the official hazard map of the municipality.

Edition 2026-09-27. Aerial photographs, landform and Meiji-era lowland data: Geospatial Information Authority of Japan (GSI), processed by Japan Time Atlas. Memorial data: GSI Natural Disaster Memorials, summarised and translated by Japan Time Atlas.

The same ground, 1961–1969 and 2024



1961–1969 aerial photograph — GSI Tiles *ort_old10*, cropped and annotated by Japan Time Atlas. North is up; the frame is identical in both images.



2024 annual orthophoto — GSI Tiles *nendophoto2024*, cropped and annotated by Japan Time Atlas. Capture dates within a mosaic can differ from place to place.

How to compare. Anchor on features that rarely move — river banks, rail lines, shrine and temple grounds, main roads — then look for what changed around them. Differences in tone come from film, camera and season, not from the land itself.

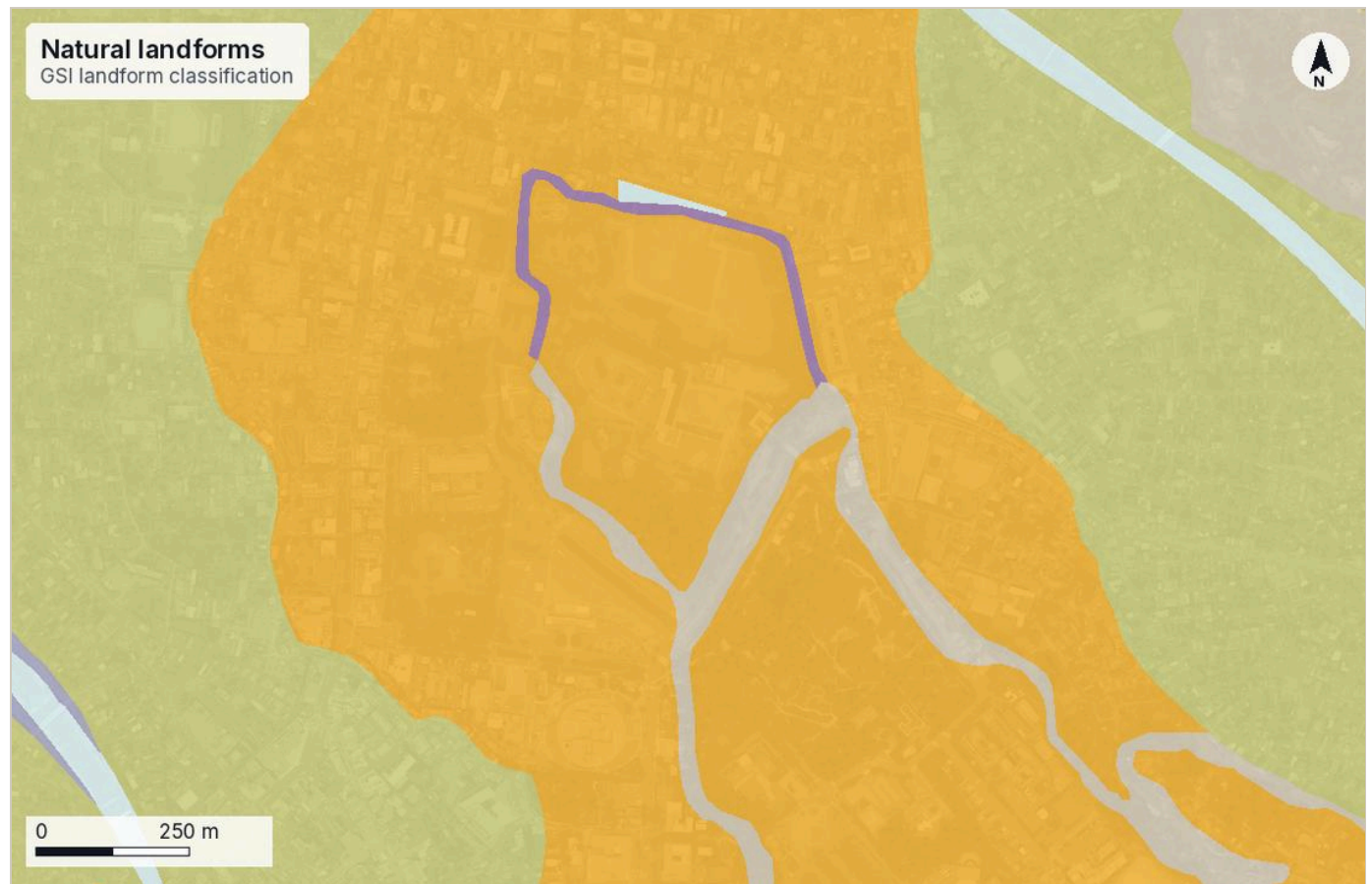
The decades in between

Every further GSI series that covers the same frame, oldest first. Each series is a compilation: photographs within one series were taken on different dates, which is why seams and changes of tone can appear inside a frame.



1974-1978 · GSI Tiles *gazo1*, processed

Rivers, shorelines and terraces



Natural landforms as classified by GSI, over a recent aerial photograph in gray. Dark blue outlines mark former river channels.



What the main landforms mean

Plateaus and terraces (50%). Flat ground standing in steps above its surroundings, left behind as the land around it was eroded. River flooding is rarely a threat unless the terrace is only slightly above the river; watch the slopes at its edges. Firm ground: shaking is relatively weak and liquefaction is unlikely.

Alluvial fan (41%). Gently sloping ground spreading fan-like from a valley mouth, built from sediment dropped by floods. Floodwater from the mountains, and debris flows near the valley mouth. Relatively firm ground; a slight liquefaction tendency on the lower fan.

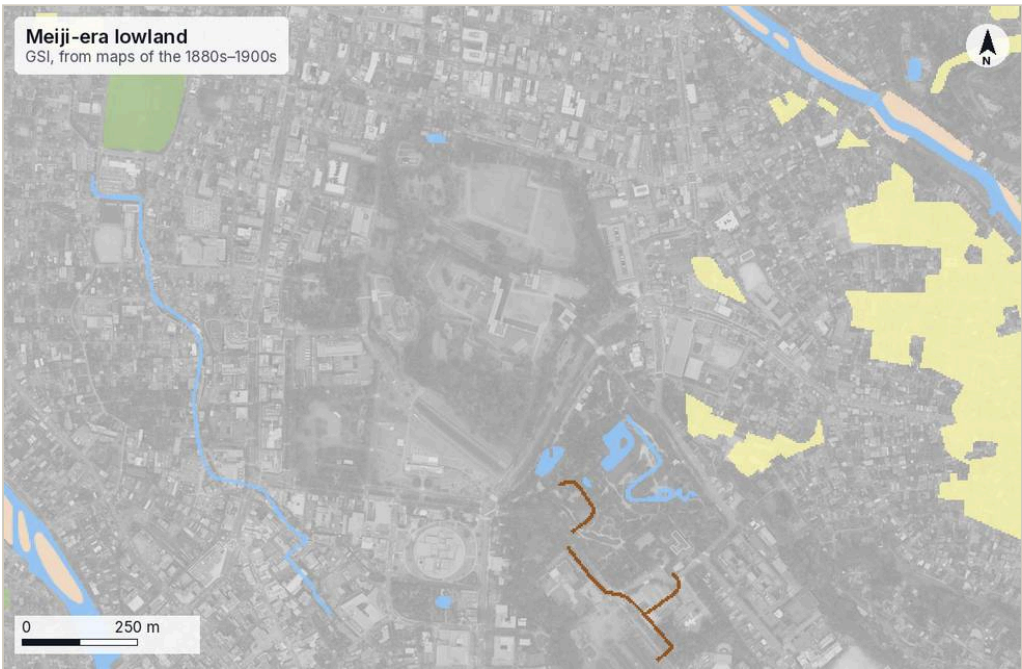
Mountain and hill slopes (6.2%). Ridges, valleys and fairly steep ground, including terrace-scarp slopes and volcanic ground. Heavy rain or earthquakes can trigger slope failures, debris flows and landslides.

Descriptions translated and condensed from GSI's landform-classification legend. They describe tendencies of each landform type, not the condition of any individual plot.

Fill, reclamation and the fields beneath the town



Hatching: man-made ground as classified by GSI. Teal outlines: former sea, river or pond. Dark blue outlines: former river channels.



GSI “Meiji-era lowland” data, traced from topographic maps of the 1880s–1900s; GSI warns that positions can be off by a considerable distance, especially in the Kanto and Kinki regions. Only low, wet or open ground was traced: towns, dry fields and forest of the period are left blank.

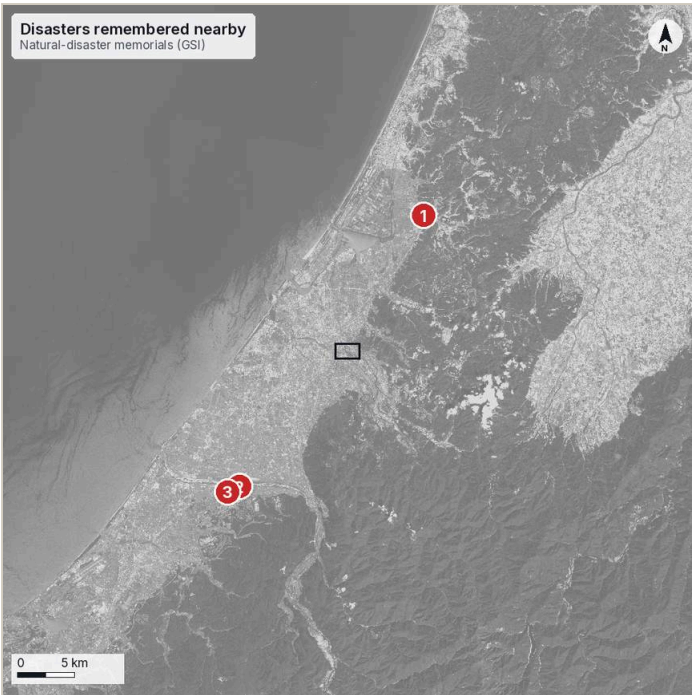
Man-made ground

 Cut ground 0.9%

Meiji-era lowland

-  Rice paddy 5.7%
-  River, pond or sea 1.6%
-  Uncultivated land 0.9%
-  Sand and gravel 0.7%

Memorials to natural disasters nearby



Numbered memorials; the black rectangle is the study area of this brief. Frame 60 km across.

Fewer than three memorials stand within 3 km of the study area, so the nearest ones within 30 km are listed.

	Memorial	Disaster	Erected	Distance
1	Monument to the recovery from the 1964 Tsubata River flood 災害復興記念碑	San'in–Hokuriku heavy rain (Jul 1964) · flood	1969	13.5 km
2	Memorial to the 1896 Tedorì River flood at Yamada 水害記念碑	Tedorì River flood (3 Aug 1896) · flood	1899	15.1 km
3	Memorial boulders left by the 1896 flood 水害記念石	Flood (2–3 Aug 1896) · flood	unknown	16.1 km

What the memorials record

- 1. Monument to the recovery from the 1964 Tsubata River flood.** Torrential rain in July 1964 made the Tsubata River overflow, killing 3 people and flooding more than 2,500 houses in all. Repairs and a thorough improvement of the river were completed in 1969, and the monument was erected to mark the recovery.
- 2. Memorial to the 1896 Tedorì River flood at Yamada.** On the morning of 3 August 1896, after rain from the previous day, the Tedorì River embankments broke everywhere. In Yamada 2 houses were swept away, every house was flooded and most fields were lost, but a bamboo-covered embankment (jibushin) held back the torrent so homes were not fully submerged. The stone warns: “Beside a river, floods are hard to avoid.”
- 3. Memorial boulders left by the 1896 flood.** The flood of 2–3 August 1896 was “seven parts mud to three parts water”: rice fields became a riverbed of gravel, roads were buried in mud and houses were crushed. Three large boulders the flood carried here were placed in the shrine grounds as memorial stones.

Source: GSI Natural Disaster Memorials (自然災害伝承碑). English names and notes are Japan Time Atlas translations and summaries of GSI's Japanese descriptions; the memorials' own inscriptions may say more. “Erected” is the year GSI records for the monument.

Where every element comes from

- **Aerial photographs** (pp. 2–3) — Geospatial Information Authority of Japan (GSI), GSI Tiles: series *ort_old10* (1961–1969), *gazo1* (1974–1978) and *nendophoto2024*. Cropped, resized and annotated by Japan Time Atlas. List of GSI Tiles: <https://maps.gsi.go.jp/development/ichiran.html>
- **Landform classification** (pp. 4–5) — GSI landform-classification vector tiles (natural and artificial landforms), compiled by GSI from its Land Condition Maps, Flood Control Terrain Classification Maps and vulnerable-landform surveys. Rendered, measured and translated into English by Japan Time Atlas. https://github.com/gsi-cyberjapan/experimental_landformclassification
- **Meiji-era lowland** (p. 5) — GSI “明治期の低湿地” tiles and legend (https://maps.gsi.go.jp/legend/lw_legend.pdf), measured and translated by Japan Time Atlas.
- **Natural disaster memorials** (p. 6) — GSI Natural Disaster Memorials (自然災害伝承碑), registered by municipalities, <https://www.gsi.go.jp/bousaichiri/denshouhi.html>; processed by Japan Time Atlas (selection by distance, English translation and summary). Memorial photographs are not reproduced.
- GSI content is used under the GSI Content Terms of Use, which follow the Public Data License v1.0 (PDL1.0, compatible with CC BY 4.0). Data retrieved 2026-09-27.
- **Outline of Japan** — Data of Japan / JapanPrefGeoJson (public domain), simplified.

Method

The study area is a fixed rectangle of 2.2 × 1.4 km. Every GSI photo series that covers at least 85% of it is included; the newest annual orthophoto covering at least 90% of it is used as “now”, with any gap filled from GSI's latest seamless mosaic. Landform shares are areas of the rectangle measured on GSI's polygons at zoom level 14, each class merged before measuring. Meiji-era shares count map pixels by legend color. Memorials are selected by straight-line distance from the center of the study area.

Limits

Historical series are mosaics of photographs taken on different dates; GSI publishes the flight date of each photograph. Landform data record conditions at the time of survey. Nothing in this brief shows present-day access, safety or opening hours.

Area Dossier. The same district with a 4–8 page English history, written from Japanese library sources and cited page by page.

Deep Research. A single hamlet or address, researched in libraries and archives.

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